

Jargon Buster

PVR: Abbreviation for Personal Video Recorder, this software allows a TV tuner to record video content in real-time.

Timeshifting: Timeshifting is a feature of PVR that allows you to pause, replay or skip a portion of a live TV programme. You have absolute control over how you watch on TV.

MPEG: MPEG is a group (Moving Picture Experts Group) that develops standards for digital audio and video compression. There are several versions of this standard, including MPEG-1, MPEG-2 and MPEG-4.

MPEG-1: This standard was designed to code progressive video at a transmission rate of 1.5 Mbps. It is used in video CDs, but gave way to the new MPEG-2 standard.

MPEG-2: This standard was designed to code transmission rates above 4 Mbps, and is used in DVD and digital broadcast TV. It is superior to MPEG-1 in terms of picture quality and sound clarity.

MPEG-4: This is a relatively new standard, and is aimed at converging streaming

media from different sources.

NTSC: This stands for National Television Standards Committee, which developed the protocol for colour television broadcast transmission and reception in the US.

As a matter of fact, NTSC signals have been used in the US and Japan since 1954, and have hardly been altered since their inception, except for the addition of new parameters for colour signals such as Hue and Tint control.

Also, NTSC signals are interlaced, and an NTSC TV image has 525 horizontal lines per frame. Every other line is dropped, and thus it takes two screen scans to complete one image. 29.97 frames are scanned every second.

PAL: Phase Alternation Line is the standard that was developed in Germany is used in India and Europe.

In the PAL standard, the horizontal image has 625 horizontal lines per frame. 25 frames are scanned every second. A

slight colour variation is seen between the PAL and NTSC standards.

SECAM: This stands for Système Électronique Couleur Avec Mémoire and was put forward by Henri de France in Paris. SECAM is prevalent in some parts of Europe—mainly in France, Russia and countries of the former Soviet Union where it was adopted in 1967.

In the SECAM system, the luminance information is transmitted in the usual manner, the chrominance signal is interleaved with it, and the colour information is reproduced with minimal errors.

NICAM stereo: This stands for Near Instantaneous Companded Audio Multiplex, and was developed by the BBC Research Centre in the early 1980s.

NICAM stereo was first transmitted with the PAL colour broadcasting system in Britain. Interestingly, this technology improves on the sound quality of the transmitted TV signal.

The Tech-Com SSD-TV-712 has not been mentioned in this section because, quite frankly, it is a no-frills device and there was nothing noteworthy about its features. All three TV tuners featured decent OSDs.

Performance

Unfortunately, very little can be said about the performance of the external set-top TV tuners. The only tests carried out here were the number of channels detected and the image quality.

The Tech-Com and the AVerMedia Box 9 detected all the 87 TV channels, while the Box 5 could manage just 54. The image quality of the Box 9 was the best, with Box 5 not far behind.

The Broad Picture

We tested 17 TV Tuners in this test. In the internal TV tuner cards category, the Compro cards outperformed every other card.

There was somewhat of a neck-and-neck competition

between the Compro Video-Mate PVR/FM and the Mercury TV tuner card. Each had their own positives and negatives.

While the Mercury card was priced at a rock-bottom Rs 1,499, the Compro was not too expensive either at Rs 1,995. However, due to better image quality and PVR features, the Compro PVR/FM emerged the Gold winner whereas the Mercury won Silver.

In the external USB TV tuner category, the Tech-Com did make itself notable by pricing its SSD-TV-811 at Rs 2,999, as compared to nearly Rs 7,000 for the other two candidates from AVerMedia and Pinnacle.

However, since this segment is primarily aimed at laptop users, the price factor isn't as important as the features and performance.



Tech-Com
SSD-TV-712

Moreover, most laptop owners probably would not mind spending a few extra bucks for better quality. Performance-wise, the Pinnacle and AVerMedia were the only contenders for Gold. Due to better image quality, channel detection and video capture score, the Pinnacle PCTV Media-Center 100e was adjudged the winner in this category.

The last category included the external set-top TV tuners. Here, the AVerMedia Box 9 tuner performed exceptionally well—better than the Tech-Com tuner in the image quality test.

However, the AVerMedia Box 9 was priced high at Rs 8,250—You should be able to buy a decent colour TV for the price of the AVerMedia Box 9! The Tech-Com SSD-TV-712, on the other hand, was priced at a very low Rs 1,999.

Due to huge price difference, the Tech-Com SSD-TV-712 easily won first place in this category.

Most home users are opting for a TV Tuner card nowadays because of the flexibility it offers. Unlike earlier TV cards, today's cards are more user-friendly and offer an unbelievable array of features.

If you find yourself missing out on your favourite programs, or are interested in recording content from your TV to watch later, nothing beats a TV tuner! ☑

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